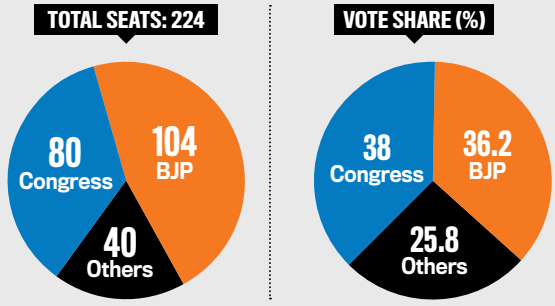
FLASHBACK TO 2018

How the Congress and BJP fared in the previous assembly election



THE CONGRESS PROMISES...

- Free electricity of up to 200 units for every household
- Rs 2,000 monthly allowance for every woman who's the head of her family
- Doubling of the free distribution of rice for below-poverty-line families to 10 kg
- Monthly allowances of Rs 3,000 for unemployed graduates and Rs 1,500 for diploma holders for two years

March 21, for instance, the Congress inducted several Madiga community leaders who belong to the 'left-hand' group of Scheduled Castes (SC)—an attempt by the Congress to bring together both the 'left' and 'right' Dalit groups which make up roughly two-thirds of the population of SCs in Karnataka estimated at 17 per cent. But three days later, CM Bommai announced a formula to apportion the 17 per cent SC quota among the four categories—'Left' (6 per cent), 'Right' (5.5 per cent), Touchables (4.5 per cent) and Others (1 per cent). This internal reservation has been a long-standing Madiga demand while also a thorny issue that previous governments had shied away from. While the aim was to bring the 'left-hand' SC groups closer to the BJP, it also makes it more difficult for the party to pacify the touchable SC castes such as Banjara and Bhovi, who are aggrieved by the internal reservation. "The internal reservation proposal sent by the BJP government is nothing but a mockery. Whoever formulated it knows it can never be implemented," argues H.P. Sudham Das, a former bureaucrat who was among the Dalit leaders who joined the Congress last month and is now the co-chairman of the campaign committee. "We have to go door to door and educate people," he says.

According to a senior Congress leader, the stiff fight the party put up in December 2021 Legislative Council polls—in which the electorate comprised gram panchayat members—was evidence that its grassroots support base was intact. The Congress's vote share in the assembly election, he points out, has not fallen below 35 per cent since 1994. "Overall, a gain of a few percentage points will help us." The Congress campaign is focused on local issues, corruption under the incumbent BJP government being its main plank. It is also banking on big-ticket welfare promises. So far, the party has announced four guarantees—free electricity of up to 200 units for every household; Rs 2,000 monthly allowance for every woman who's the head of her family; doubling the quantity of rice distributed free for below-poverty-line families to 10 kg; and monthly allowances of Rs 3,000 for unemployed graduates and Rs 1,500 for diploma-holders for two years. "Within 24 hours of coming to power, we will address the issue of unemployment for youth," Shivakumar said on April 8.

But if the BJP hasn't projected a CM candidate, the Congress, too, has left that question open-ended. While Siddaramaiah is the Congress's mass leader, the state party chief is known for his organisational skills. Both hail from southern Karnataka—the former is from Mysuru and the latter from Kanakapura, a town 60 km from Bengaluru. Till recently, however, Siddaramaiah was vacillating between his home constituency Varuna—which his son Dr Yathindra represents—and a new seat, Kolar. According to a close aide, the calculation behind considering Kolar was its mix of Dalit, minority and OBC voters, a grouping known by the Kannada acronym Ahinda, which has been Siddaramaiah's main political plank since he broke away from the Janata Dal (Secular) in 2005. At the moment, however, Siddaramaiah has settled for his old seat Varuna with son Yathindra having stepped aside. The party will have to greenlight the plan to contest a second seat from Kolar, he says. But, the BJP, looking to tie down both Siddaramaiah and Shivakumar to their constituencies, is fielding senior ministers from Bengaluru—V. Somanna and R. Ashoka—in Varuna and Kanakapura, respectively.

THE CONGRESS CAMPAIGN IS FOCUSED ON LOCAL ISSUES, CORRUPTION UNDER THE BJP GOVT BEING ITS MAIN PLANK

Beyond the Siddaramaiah-Shivakumar factor, however, several other Congress leaders see themselves as dark horses. "There are many capable contenders for the CM's post, including me," senior leader M.B. Patil, who heads the campaign committee, told an interviewer recently. As Patil put it, the tallest leaders were AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge and Siddaramaiah, followed by the next rung, which included Shivakumar and himself. Incidentally, Shivakumar, too, brought up Kharge's name in an interview. Asked about it at a recent press conference in Bengaluru, he replied: "I'd love to work under him (Kharge). He's senior to me by 20 years." To some, that appeared more a googly aimed at his primary rival. The scenario of several contenders, political observers say, is a fairly normal occurrence in the Congress. Currently, however, the key challenge before the party is how it navigates the final leg of the battle. ■